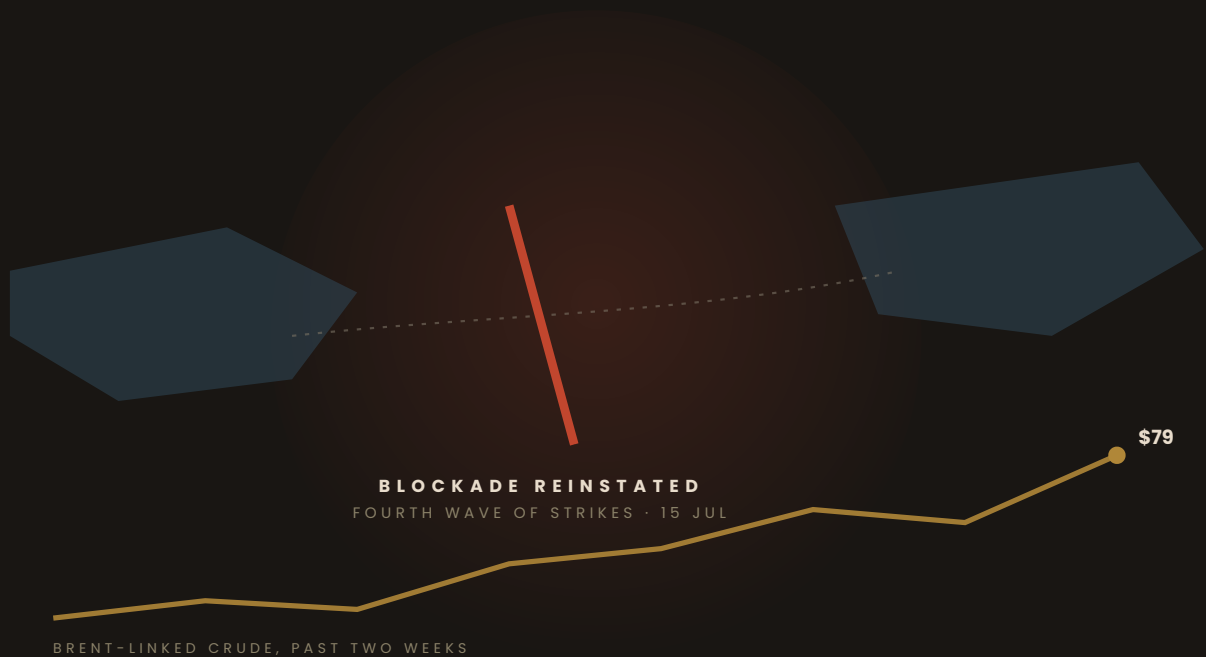


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY · 16 JULY 2026



THE WORLD

The 20% Hormuz toll is gone for good; a fourth wave of US strikes makes this the war's deadliest week yet

PROPERTY

Singapore developers launch nothing at all in June — a first in nineteen years of URA records

SCREEN & SOUND

Steve Lacy breaks a three-year silence tomorrow, in the most crowded release week of the summer

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TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

The parts that kept running anyway

A week where a parliament held its scheduled vote, a market posted its scheduled data, and a ramen counter finally got its scheduled review — all while a blockade and a fourth wave of strikes ran in the background regardless.

THE DESKS

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The Little Red Dot — two ministers win S\$460,000 from Bloomberg as a judge finds "unprecedented" malice

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FROM THE DESK

"You have power over your mind — not outside events. Realize this, and you will find strength."

— Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, Book VI (written on campaign, c. 170s AD)

Aurelius wrote those words between military campaigns he did not choose and could not end on his own schedule — which is roughly the position every institution in this issue found itself in this week. A parliament voted anyway. A statistics office published anyway. A film opened its review embargo anyway. The weather does not get a vote on whether the calendar proceeds; only the participants do.

THE STRIP — AS OF WEDNESDAY 15 JUL NY CLOSE (ASIA THURSDAY-OPEN PENDING)

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	NOTE
S&P 500	7,572.40	+0.38% Wed
US 10Y	~4.56%	eased , second session
DXY	~100.6	-0.3% , 2nd down day
USD/SGD	~1.2904	last confirmed, Wed
Brent	~\$79.1	-0.35% Wed
Gold	~\$4,073	flat, +0.16%
BTC	~\$64.6k	+~4% Wed, fading

Levels held to their last confirmed print at Singapore Thursday press time; several instruments are carried at Wednesday's NY close rather than guessed at Thursday-open. Market data is explanation, not advice — see Macro, [p15](#).

THE WORLD · GULF CRISIS

The 20% Hormuz toll is gone for good; a fourth wave of US strikes makes this the war's deadliest week yet

The reversal flagged in No. 43 has hardened into settled policy. What hasn't stopped is the blockade underneath it — or the casualty count.

The 20 percent Hormuz "reimbursement fee" that President Trump announced and then reversed inside 25 hours (No. 43) has not resurfaced; Trump confirmed Tuesday it is being replaced permanently by trade and investment agreements with Gulf states, not revived as a fallback. What has continued, and escalated, is everything the toll was never really about: CENTCOM confirmed a fourth round of US strikes on Iranian targets Wednesday, hitting an army barracks and killing at least seven Iranian troops while wounding roughly 260 — the highest single-strike casualty count of the conflict so far. The naval blockade Washington reinstated Tuesday remains in force.¹

Iran said US strikes have now killed more than 30 civilians over the preceding days and retaliated by targeting US military infrastructure in Kuwait, Bahrain and Jordan — a widening of the map from the five Gulf states it struck a week earlier. Roughly a fifth of the world's seaborne oil and gas normally transits Hormuz; the disruption has pushed US gasoline up for a second straight week, ten cents over seven days to \$3.89 a gallon, even as Brent itself eased back toward \$79 on the same cooling-inflation mood driving equities (see Macro, [p15](#)).²

China's foreign ministry called Wednesday for "the restoration of normal passage through the Strait of Hormuz as soon as possible" — a notably narrow ask that stops short of criticising either side directly, consistent with Beijing's posture through the crisis. Oman, which hosted Iran's foreign minister just hours before an earlier round of Iranian strikes hit Gulf states, has restated its condemnation of attacks on its territory without naming a side to blame.³

WASHINGTON —**CENTCOM/CNBC
FRAMING**

Presents the toll's permanent withdrawal as the diplomatic half of a two-track policy — trade deals instead of tariffs — running alongside a military posture (the blockade, the strikes) framed as protecting, not obstructing, the "free flow" of Gulf shipping.

**CHINA — STATE-MEDIA
FRAMING**

Calls simply for normal passage to resume, treating the crisis as a shared commercial risk to global trade rather than a contest to adjudicate — a framing that keeps Beijing's own large Hormuz-transiting oil imports out of the political crossfire.

**AL — GULF/GLOBAL-
JAZEERA SOUTH FRAMING**

Leads on the casualty count from the barracks strike and Iran's expanded target list, reading the toll's quiet permanent withdrawal as incidental — the story, in this framing, is that the shooting war never actually paused while the tariff story dominated headlines.

260

IRANIAN TROOPS REPORTED WOUNDED
IN WEDNESDAY'S BARRACKS STRIKE —
THE CONFLICT'S SINGLE HIGHEST-
CASUALTY STRIKE TO DATE

SOURCES · 1 CBS News live updates, "U.S. blockades Iranian ports, launches dozens of strikes," 15 Jul 2026; CNN live updates, 15 Jul 2026; Yahoo News world bulletin, 15 Jul 2026. 2 NPR, "U.S. fires a new wave of strikes on Iran," 15 Jul 2026; CNBC, "Ship traffic through Hormuz falls," 13 Jul 2026. 3 Bloomberg, "China Urges Normal Strait of Hormuz Passage," 14 Jul 2026; Al Jazeera Gulf-reaction live coverage, 12–14 Jul 2026.

THE WORLD · UKRAINE & THE WORLD CUP

Kyiv's parliament votes today on Koretskyi as PM, and Argentina reach a final France won't be in

The reshuffle flagged as pending in No. 43 reaches its scheduled vote this afternoon Kyiv time; the World Cup bracket is now fully resolved.

President Zelensky formally endorsed Naftogaz chief executive Serhii Koretskyi as his choice for prime minister on Wednesday, a day after parliament dismissed Yuliia Svyrydenko 258 votes to one (No. 43). "The priorities are clear — preparing for winter," Zelensky said, pointing to the energy-security experience Koretskyi has accumulated running Ukraine's state gas company through repeated strikes on its production facilities since May 2025. Parliament's confirmation vote is scheduled for Thursday — today, Kyiv time — with Svyrydenko tipped for a Washington-facing ambassador role.¹

In Atlanta, Argentina completed their second straight late comeback of the tournament, beating England 2-1 to reach the World Cup final: Anthony Gordon put England ahead in the 55th minute before Lionel Messi set up an Enzo Fernández equaliser in the 85th and a Lautaro Martínez winner in second-half stoppage time. Argentina now face Spain — who beat France 2-0 in the other semi-final — at New York/New Jersey's MetLife Stadium on Sunday 19 July, pitting Messi against Barcelona teenager Lamine Yamal for the first time on a World Cup pitch. England play France in Saturday's third-place match.²

Ukraine and nine European partners — Denmark, France, Germany, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Spain, Sweden and the UK — launched an "Anti-Ballistic Missile Coalition" backing the "Freya" air-defence project this week, a distinct institutional vehicle from Zelensky's separate, repeated request for 300 Patriot interceptors before winter (No. 43). Both efforts are aimed at the same target: Kyiv's power grid, which Russian strikes have hit in each of the past three winters.³

FIFA confirmed Sunday's final will proceed at MetLife Stadium as scheduled despite the Gulf-driven disruption rippling through global shipping and long-haul flight paths this month — a small footnote against a barracks strike, but one more example of a fixture running on its own calendar regardless of the news layered around it. Ukraine's own winter-prep coalition and Kyiv's parliamentary vote share the same shape, at a very different scale.⁴

THE CHATTER — READING THE MESSI COMEBACK

Both Argentina goals traced back to the same 38-year-old: pundits on ESPN's live coverage called Messi's late double-assist "the same trick twice in two rounds" after his near-identical creative burden in the quarter-final. Argentine outlets framed it plainly as the last World Cup of Messi's career resolving into one final act against the sport's most-hyped teenager.

IN BRIEF

Congo's Ebola outbreak. Deaths in eastern DRC have passed 700, with roughly 80 percent of new cases now emerging from chains of transmission health officials can no longer trace — a sign, per WHO-adjacent reporting, that the outbreak is outrunning containment.

Fontainebleau fire, contained. Firefighters brought a forest fire near Paris under control Wednesday; five people have been arrested on suspicion of arson.

US daylight saving reform. The House passed the Sunshine Protection Act, moving a permanent end to twice-yearly clock changes a step closer, with the President signalling support.

258-1

RADA VOTE TO DISMISS PM SVYRYDENKO — THE SCALE OF CONSENSUS BEHIND A RESHUFFLE THAT REACHES ITS OWN CONFIRMATION VOTE TODAY

The confirmation vote lands on a day this issue's press schedule can only note as pending rather than report as done — deliberately held that way rather than guessed at, in keeping with this desk's rule that a scheduled vote is not the same fact as a completed one. See The Long Read, [p21](#), for why that distinction is this week's actual throughline.

SOURCES · 1 Al Jazeera, "Zelenskyy backs state energy company chief Koretskyi for new Ukraine PM," 15 Jul 2026; Kyiv Independent, "Ukraine's parliament dismisses prime minister," 14 Jul 2026. 2 ESPN, Al Jazeera, FIFA match centre, "England v Argentina 1-2," 15 Jul 2026; Yahoo Sports, "Spain storms into World Cup final," 15 Jul 2026. 3 Kyiv Independent, Coalition of the Willing readout, 13-14 Jul 2026. 4 FIFA match centre schedule confirmation, Jul 2026.

SINGAPORE · COURTS & PRESS

Two ministers win S\$460,000 from Bloomberg as a judge finds "unprecedented" malice

A defamation suit over a December 2024 property story ends with the harshest judicial language this desk has logged against a foreign outlet in years.

Home Affairs Minister K Shanmugam and Manpower Minister Tan See Leng were awarded S\$230,000 each in damages Tuesday after Justice Audrey Lim found that a December 2024 Bloomberg article — "Singapore Mansion Deals Are Increasingly Shrouded in Secrecy" — defamed them by linking their Good Class Bungalow purchases to secrecy, opacity and money laundering. The judge found Bloomberg and reporter Low De Wei had acted with malice, ruling that internal correspondence showed "the genesis of the Article lay not in a story about trends in the GCB market... but in an interest in the claimants."¹

The ministers had argued the article's framing implied wrongdoing without evidence; Bloomberg's defence — that the piece was a legitimate look at transparency trends in Singapore's prime residential market — did not persuade the court, which described the malice finding as resting on the outlet's own internal record rather than inference. The Committee to Protect Journalists warned the ruling "could chill reporting in Singapore," a caution echoing the concerns this desk has flagged before around the city-state's defamation regime and foreign-press coverage of local elites.²

THE SCEPTIC — PRESS-FREEDOM READ

CPJ's statement argues the ruling sends "a clear signal" to international outlets that critical property-market reporting touching senior officials carries real legal exposure, regardless of how the story is framed — a chilling-effect concern this desk takes seriously even while noting the court's finding rested on documented internal motive, not merely an unflattering topic.

ALSO THIS WEEK

SG–Indonesia defence alumni. The two militaries launched a new alumni initiative Tuesday meant to connect generations of officers trained together — a soft-power complement to the existing bilateral defence pact.

Haze watch, early. Malaysian authorities warned the region could see conditions echoing the severe 1997–98 El Niño haze event; ground readings in Singapore remain calm for now, and NEA has issued no elevated advisory.

S\$460K

COMBINED DAMAGES AWARDED TO THE TWO MINISTERS — ONE OF THE LARGER DEFAMATION AWARDS THIS DESK HAS LOGGED AGAINST A GLOBAL NEWSWIRE

Tuesday's Q2 GDP beat (5.7% YoY, flagged in No. 43) continues to frame the week's other Singapore stories: a manufacturing-led surprise strong enough that a defamation verdict and a bilateral defence initiative both landed on a calmer economic backdrop than the regional Gulf-driven risk headlines might suggest.

SOURCES · 1 Law.com International, "Singapore Court Orders Bloomberg to Pay \$356,000 in Defamation Damages," 14 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, "Singapore Ministers Win Defamation Case Against Bloomberg," 14 Jul 2026; Mothership.SG, 14 Jul 2026. 2 Committee to Protect Journalists, "CPJ warns Bloomberg defamation ruling could chill reporting in Singapore," 15 Jul 2026; SCMP, "Bloomberg accused of 'unprecedented' malice," Jul 2026. Haze: Bernama regional headlines roundup, 15 Jul 2026.

PROPERTY · NEW SALES

Zero new launches in June — a first in nineteen years of URA developer-sales records

Developers sold just 156 units, the weakest month since February 2024, without releasing a single new project to the market.

Singapore developers sold 156 new private homes in June, excluding executive condominiums — a 65.1 percent fall from May's 447 units and 42.6 percent below June 2025 — and, more strikingly, launched not a single new private residential project during the month, the first time that has happened since URA began publishing monthly developer-sales data in June 2007. May, by contrast, had seen 357 fresh units released. Analysts attribute the pause largely to the June school-holiday lull rather than a demand collapse, with a rebound expected once July launches resume.¹

The first half of 2026 as a whole lands softer too: developers sold an estimated 4,164 new private homes excluding ECs, against 4,587 over the same period in 2025 — a real, if modest, year-on-year decline. Separately, URA's flash estimate put private home prices up 0.9 percent in Q2, a pace this desk will revisit once the confirmed figure lands alongside HDB's resale numbers.²

THE WATCHLIST — TWO GLS/EN-BLOC THREADS STILL OPEN

The Bayshore Drive mixed-use GLS tender — Singapore's largest such site, potentially yielding 1,280 homes above the future Bedok South MRT station — closed Wednesday. Analysts project two to six bids and a top offer near \$1,150-1,306 psf ppr, a land quantum that could approach \$2 billion; URA typically takes two to four weeks to announce a result, so this desk holds the outcome as pending rather than guessing at it.

IN BRIEF

Balestier Regency, 4th attempt. The 72-unit freehold condo's tender closed 9 July at a S\$255m guide price; no result has been announced as this issue closes.

High Point, 5th attempt. The Mount Elizabeth freehold tower's collective-sale bid, guided at S\$580m, remains open with no confirmed outcome.

0

NEW PRIVATE-HOME LAUNCHES IN JUNE 2026 — THE FIRST ZERO-LAUNCH MONTH IN NINETEEN YEARS OF URA RECORDS

Analysts reading the June collapse point squarely at timing rather than demand: several major projects held back their launches to avoid competing with the June school-holiday travel window, when a meaningful share of the buyer pool is typically overseas rather than viewing showflats. A cluster of launches is expected to land across July and August instead, meaning this desk's next Property lead is likely to describe the opposite

problem — several large projects competing for the same buyer pool in the same month.

The Bayshore Drive site's scale is worth dwelling on for what it says about developer appetite despite the quiet month: a projected 1,280 homes above a single MRT station, with bids potentially approaching \$2 billion, would be one of the largest single land parcels transacted in Singapore this cycle.

SOURCES · 1 99.co, "Developers' new home sales fall to a 2-year low in June," 15 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, "Singapore Home Sales Drop to Two-Year Low on Holiday Lull," 15 Jul 2026; URA developer sales release, 15 Jul 2026. 2 URA flash estimate, 2nd Quarter 2026 private residential property price index, Jul 2026. Bayshore Drive: PropertyNet.SG, Stacked Homes, URA media release pr26-23, Jul 2026. Balestier/High Point: EdgeProp, TracyGoh.sg, Jul 2026.

TECHNOLOGY · AI CHIPS

Nvidia's new "whitelist" fails over half its past Asian buyers, as DeepSeek V4 graduates to official release

A compliance crackdown tightens who in Singapore can even buy the good chips, the same week a Chinese rival's flagship model leaves preview.

Nvidia confirmed Tuesday it has implemented a stringent new "whitelist" compliance system for Asian customers, screening buyers to prevent AI chips from being rerouted to China via third parties. Enhanced scrutiny specifically names Singapore, Malaysia and Japan as focus markets, and Nvidia says more than half of past customers evaluated under the new checks have failed — a sharp narrowing of the eligible-buyer pool in exactly the markets this reader's own home-AI-lab interests sit closest to.¹

Separately, a Trump administration trade official said Tuesday that a "trivial" number of Nvidia H200 chips have shipped to China under a US export licence, without specifying volumes or buyers — the first confirmed, if minuscule, crack in the export wall since May's rules extended licensing requirements to Blackwell-class chips bound for China or Macau.²

THE CHATTER — WHAT THE WHITELIST ACTUALLY CATCHES

Trade-compliance discussion threads read the Singapore/Malaysia emphasis as a direct response to well-documented smuggling routes uncovered over the past two years, not a comment on either country's own policy — reroute risk, not local demand, is the trigger. Practical read for a Singapore-based buyer: expect more paperwork and longer lead times on data-centre-class cards, less change at the consumer GPU tier this desk's Home Lab section covers on the facing page.

IN BRIEF

DeepSeek V4 goes official. DeepSeek's V4 model — in open-weight preview since 24 April — graduates to official release this week with a 1-million-token context window standard across the lineup, alongside a new peak-hour API pricing scheme (2x baseline, Beijing 9am-noon and 2-6pm). Legacy deepseek-chat/deepseek-reasoner model names retire 24 July.

China's Q2 GDP lands Thursday. A print due after this issue closes, worth reading against the same chip-export tightening squeezing both countries' AI ambitions this week.

TSMC's own Q2 earnings report the same week, giving the clearest read yet on how much of the whitelist-driven order uncertainty is actually showing up in foundry bookings.

>50%

SHARE OF PAST ASIAN CUSTOMERS NVIDIA SAYS HAVE FAILED ITS NEW COMPLIANCE WHITELIST

The whitelist's mechanics matter more than the headline number: Nvidia is understood to be cross-checking shipping manifests, corporate ownership structures and prior order histories against known reroute patterns, rather than applying a simple country-of-registration filter. That's precisely why a legitimate Singapore-based buyer with no China ties can still get caught in the net — the system is tuned to catch structure, not intent, and a buyer's own paperwork trail now matters as much as its stated end-use.³

DeepSeek's graduation to official release is a reminder that the compute-export story and the model-capability story are now permanently entangled: a Chinese lab is shipping a frontier-class, million-token-context model on roughly the same week Washington tightens the screws on the chips such labs would need to train the next one domestically. Whether that gap closes or widens over the coming year is arguably the single most consequential open question this desk tracks — bigger, in the long run, than any one quarter's chip-stock move.

SOURCES · 1 Gurufocus, "NVIDIA Tightens Compliance for AI Chip Sales Amid U.S. Export Controls," 14 Jul 2026. 2 CNBC, "U.S. trade official says 'very few' Nvidia H200 AI chips have been shipped to China," 14 Jul 2026; Bloomberg, "Small Amount of Nvidia AI Chips Sold to China Via US License," 14 Jul 2026. DeepSeek: TechNode, "DeepSeek to launch V4 in mid-July with new peak-time API pricing," 30 Jun 2026; DeepSeek API docs news, Jul 2026. 3 Gurufocus compliance-mechanics reporting, 14 Jul 2026.

THE HOME LAB · BUYER'S MARKET

The compliance crackdown that's meant for data centres still narrows a Singapore buyer's options

Enhanced scrutiny targets enterprise-scale orders, but it lands in a market where GPU street prices are already the worst they've been all year.

Nvidia's new Asia-focused whitelist (see p7) is aimed at bulk, enterprise-scale orders rather than the single-card purchases a home-AI-lab builder makes — but the practical read-through for a Singapore-based buyer is still worth flagging: distributors facing tighter compliance paperwork on data-centre SKUs tend to pass process friction down the chain, and several regional retailer forums are already reporting slower restocks on the higher-VRAM consumer cards that share supply lines with enterprise parts.¹

That friction lands on top of an already-bad GDDR7 shortage this desk flagged in No. 41: RTX 5090 street pricing has climbed further, from roughly \$4,300 in June to \$4,300-5,000+ as of mid-July, more than double MSRP, while the RTX 4090 remains discontinued and now trades scarce on the used market above its old retail price. The standing advice hasn't changed: this is not the month to buy a GPU for local LLM inference unless the workload genuinely can't wait.²

For a reader already running a home AI lab rather than shopping for a first card, the more useful move this month is software, not hardware: DeepSeek V4's jump to a 1-million-token context window (facing page) matters far more for a ComfyUI-adjacent local-inference setup than any single GPU refresh, since it changes what's feasible to run locally on existing VRAM rather than requiring new silicon at all. Quantised, community-distilled versions of frontier models continue to close the gap with cloud-hosted originals faster than hardware prices are falling.

THE WORKAROUND — WHAT FORUMS ARE ACTUALLY BUYING

With Nvidia's Blackwell tier scarce and pricey, self-hosting forums are pointing budget-conscious builders toward AMD's RX 9070 XT (16GB GDDR6, ~\$630-700), which has largely dodged the shortage, and the Radeon RX 7900 XTX (24GB) as the value pick under \$1,000 for Llama-class 70B models at Q4 quantisation on ROCm 7.2 — genuinely usable, if a step behind CUDA-first tooling.

STILL ON THE SHELF

DeepSeek V4's 1M context window (facing page) is a genuine local-hosting draw once open weights catch up to the official release — worth revisiting once independent VRAM-requirement benchmarks land.

\$4.3–5K

CURRENT RTX 5090 STREET PRICE — MORE THAN DOUBLE MSRP, AND STILL CLIMBING SINCE JUNE

The practical shopping list for now: hold off on a Blackwell-tier card unless a specific workload genuinely can't wait, watch RTX 5090 pricing into August once the compliance dust from Nvidia's whitelist settles and enterprise demand potentially eases off consumer-adjacent supply lines, and treat the AMD ROCm path as a legitimate stopgap rather than a permanent compromise — the tooling gap with CUDA has narrowed meaningfully over the past two quarters, per self-hosting forum benchmarks this desk continues to track.

Two supply stories, one shared shortage: an export-compliance crackdown built for enterprise buyers and a consumer memory shortage built entirely by demand — both are quietly the same story about how tight the Blackwell-generation supply chain has become, from Bandar Abbas's oil tankers to a home office in Bishan.

SOURCES · 1 Gurufocus, Nvidia compliance coverage, 14 Jul 2026 (see p7); regional retailer/forum restock commentary, Jul 2026. 2 PromptQuorum, "Local LLM Hardware Requirements 2026," Jul 2026; Compute Market, "Best AMD GPU for Local LLM Inference 2026," Jul 2026.

THE KIT · WEARABLES

Samsung's Galaxy Glasses are confirmed for 22 July, built with Google, Qualcomm and Warby Parker

Two frame styles, a Snapdragon AR1 chip and a Spotify-via-Gemini party trick round out the fullest picture yet of Meta's first real challenger.

Samsung will unveil its first AI smart glasses at Galaxy Unpacked in London on 22 July, per new video footage and leaked photos this week — the launch flagged as upcoming in No. 43 now has real specifics. The Galaxy Glasses ship in two styles: a rounded, fashion-forward Gentle Monster frame with tinted lenses, and a classic clear-lens Warby Parker model. Both run on a Qualcomm Snapdragon AR1 chipset, weigh around 50g and pack a 155mAh battery, with photos captured on the glasses surfacing directly in the NowBar on a paired Galaxy phone.¹

The most distinctive feature so far: the glasses' camera can read a room and suggest or build Spotify playlists through Gemini, based on surroundings and mood — a genuinely new party trick versus Meta's Ray-Ban line, which still leads on raw camera-glasses volume but has drawn backlash of its own this year over a tamper-proof LED kill switch and reports of an always-on "super sensing" prototype (No. 43).²

The two-frame strategy is a deliberate contrast with Meta's own approach: rather than chase every price tier and style at once, Samsung is betting that a genuinely wearable-all-day design — in partnership with an actual eyewear brand in Warby Parker, not just a co-branding exercise — matters more to first-time buyers than raw feature count. Early leaked footage shows the touchpad and camera-button placement borrowing directly from Meta's Ray-Ban layout, a sign Samsung isn't trying to reinvent smart-glasses ergonomics, only to out-execute the software layer sitting behind them.³

THE CHATTER — META'S SUBSCRIPTION WRINKLE

Meta has quietly added "Meta One," a subscription required to unlock the full feature set of its own glasses — a monetisation move XR-community threads are reading as a tacit admission that hardware margins alone don't cover the AI compute. The Information separately reports Meta has four more glasses models and a standalone "AI Pendant" planned before year-end, a crowded roadmap Samsung's cleaner two-SKU launch is positioned directly against.

IN BRIEF

RingConn Gen 3 review. The \$349 titanium smart ring lasted 17 days on a single charge in testing against its own 14-day claim, added blood-pressure trend tracking and a silent vibration motor, and undercuts the Oura Ring 5's entry price by roughly \$50 — heart-rate accuracy improved over Gen 2 but still trails Oura and the Galaxy Ring.

Gen 2 owners: reviewers say hold off upgrading if your current ring still clears ten days of battery life — the vibration motor and apnea screening are the only genuinely new reasons to move to Gen 3.

50g

WEIGHT OF SAMSUNG'S GALAXY GLASSES — ROUGHLY IN LINE WITH A STANDARD PAIR OF ACETATE FRAMES

Whether the Spotify-via-Gemini trick becomes a genuine differentiator or a demo-day gimmick will depend on latency and battery draw in real use — camera-based context detection is exactly the kind of always-on sensing that drains a 155mAh cell fastest, and it's the same category of feature that has drawn privacy criticism toward Meta's glasses all year (No. 43). Samsung has not yet detailed exactly how much of that processing happens on-device versus in the cloud, a gap this desk will press for an answer on once review units ship.

SOURCES · 1 AndroidHeadlines, "Samsung's Galaxy Glasses Look a Lot Like Meta's," 15 Jul 2026; Gadget Hacks, "Samsung Galaxy Glasses Launch July 2026," Jul 2026. 2 Skarredghost/The Ghost Howls, "The XR Week Peek," 6 Jul 2026; 9to5Google, "Meta reportedly has several new smart glasses in the works," 1 Jun 2026. RingConn: The Gadgeteer, "RingConn Gen 3 review," 12 Jun 2026. 3 AndroidHeadlines, "This Galaxy Glasses Feature Could Be Enough to Pull You Away From Meta's Glasses," Jul 2026.

CONNECTED HOME · MATTER

Matter's first camera arrives, a year after the standard promised one

Aqara's G350 becomes the standard's proof of concept for video devices, with SmartThings and Home Assistant both racing to catch up.

Aqara's Camera Hub G350, the world's first Matter v1.5-compliant camera, is now shipping with firmware enabling full Matter camera functionality — a milestone this desk has been waiting on since Matter 1.5's camera and doorbell support was ratified. SmartThings has added bridged support via a beta firmware series (60.x) open to voluntary testers, letting a G350 camera feed appear as a native SmartThings device rather than a third-party bolt-on; a general release is expected once beta feedback settles.¹

Home Assistant's own 2026.7 release (No. 43) turns out to matter more for this than it first appeared: the rewritten `matter.js` server's compliance with Matter 1.5.1 is precisely what unlocks camera and doorbell device categories inside HA — meaning the server-overhaul story and the camera story are the same upgrade, arriving in two visible pieces a fortnight apart. New Matter diagnostic sensors (Reboot Count, Uptime, Boot Reason) also ship this cycle, finally answering the question every Matter user eventually hits when a device drops off the network unexplained.²

The camera and doorbell categories have been the standard's most conspicuous gap since Matter 1.0 launched — video devices carry harder real-time streaming and codec requirements than the lock, sensor and light-bulb categories that dominated the standard's first two years, which is why it has taken until Matter 1.5.1 for a genuinely native implementation to ship. Aqara's decision to be first, ahead of larger platform holders like Google and Amazon, mirrors the pattern this desk flagged with the G350's original Matter camera debut in China earlier this year — smaller, more

THE CHATTER — EARLY TESTER REACTION

Aqara's own developer forum shows testers pleased with local, low-latency camera control but flagging that motion recording and PTZ (pan-tilt-zoom) support are still pending in a later firmware drop — a "works, but not finished" verdict typical of a genuinely first-of-kind Matter device rather than a mature product.

IN BRIEF

Matter-certified soil moisture sensors now show up in Home Assistant for the first time — a small addition, but one more device category the standard has closed since launch.

HA's Activity feed rebuild turns a raw event log into a navigable timeline in the same 2026.7 release — a genuinely useful troubleshooting upgrade for anyone running a large Zigbee/Thread mesh.

Purpose-specific automation triggers exit opt-in testing and become the default experience for all Home Assistant users in this cycle too — one less thing to hunt for in the beta-features menu.

1.5.1

THE MATTER SPEC VERSION BOTH THE G350 CAMERA AND HA'S REWRITTEN SERVER NOW COMPLY WITH — THE SHARED UNLOCK BEHIND THIS WEEK'S CAMERA NEWS

agile vendors reaching new device categories before the ecosystem giants do.

For a Lutron-based household weighing a Home Assistant migration, the practical read is unchanged from No. 43's assessment: this week's news strengthens the case for waiting on the video side specifically, since a first-generation implementation with pending PTZ and recording features is exactly the kind of thing worth letting mature for one more firmware cycle before anchoring a camera setup to it.

Two device categories, two different maturity clocks: locks and sensors took roughly three years from Matter 1.0 to feel genuinely dependable; cameras are starting that same clock now, in a market already several years into treating the standard as settled. Worth remembering the first year of any new category is rarely the one to build a permanent setup around.

SOURCES · 1 Matter Alpha, "Matter camera first look with Aqara G350 and SmartThings," Jul 2026; derekseaman.com, "Aqara Camera Hub G350: World's First Matter v1.5 Camera," Mar 2026 (device background). 2 Home-assistant.io, "2026.7: Automations that speak your language," 1 Jul 2026; TechTimes, "Home Assistant 2026.7 Arrives July 1 With Intent-Based Automations and Matter Server Overhaul," 29 Jun 2026.

THE GOOD LIFE · WATCHES

Sotheby's brings its watch sale to Tokyo this week — a real test of whether the independent premium travels

After a spring of independent watchmakers repeatedly out-earning the storied maisons in Geneva and New York, the format faces its first Asia-market test.

Sotheby's opens a four-day watch sale in Tokyo on 21 July, its first major standalone Asia watch auction of the year, landing squarely inside the city's Golden Route tourist season. The sale's real interest isn't the catalogue — Sotheby's has not yet published full lot-by-lot estimates — but the question it tests: independent watchmakers have spent this year repeatedly out-earning the storied Swiss maisons at Phillips' Geneva and New York sales, a pattern collectors read as a genuine shift toward scarcity and a single maker's hand over a house's marketing budget. Whether that appetite is a Geneva-and-New-York phenomenon or a genuinely global one is, this week, still an open question rather than a settled fact.¹

Tokyo is a meaningful test market precisely because it already has the deepest independent-watchmaker collector culture outside Switzerland — the city's grey-market and pre-owned scene has anchored fair-value pricing on names like F.P. Journe and Voutilainen for years, ahead of the West's own recent enthusiasm. This desk will report Sotheby's actual results once the gavel falls, rather than assume the Geneva pattern simply repeats.²

IN BRIEF — SINGAPORE, RIGHT NOW

Jewel's LEGO Botanicals. Jewel Changi Airport is hosting Southeast Asia's largest LEGO Botanicals activation through 30 August — over 800,000 bricks, two 2-metre rose installations at Forest Valley, and Japanese/Mediterranean/English-countryside garden displays at Canopy Park; a stamp rally across seven locations runs to 26 July. A genuinely good family half-day, walking distance from a Changi transit.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Rolex Daytona "Rainbow" (First State Auctions). Still awaiting its hammer price after the 19 July sale — held open rather than guessed at (No. 43).

Apple AirPods Max 2. Newly unveiled; a first independent audio review has not yet landed.

Sennheiser HDB 630. A new audiophile-tier entrant drawing early best-of-2026 shortlist mentions; a full review is still pending.

21–24 JUL

SOTHEBY'S TOKYO WATCH SALE DATES
— THIS DESK HOLDS THE RESULT OPEN
RATHER THAN GUESSING AT IT

The honest caveat this desk applies every time an auction is still pending: a strong sale in Tokyo would be genuinely informative about where independent-watchmaker demand is headed next; a soft one would be equally informative, and neither should be assumed in advance just because the Geneva and New York results ran hot. That discipline — reporting the result once it exists rather than the trend line extrapolated

forward — is the same one this issue's Long Read ([p21](#)) argues for more broadly.

For a reader already planning a Tokyo trip around this year's watch and camera-street circuit, Sotheby's preview exhibition is typically open to the public ahead of the sale itself — a genuinely worthwhile half-day stop even for a non-bidder, and one that pairs naturally with the same city's audio-retail crawl this desk has flagged before.

SOURCES · 1 The Art Newspaper, "Phillips leans on luxury watches in first half of 2026," 10 Jul 2026 (independent-watchmaker demand context); Sotheby's watches department calendar, Jul 2026. 2 Sotheby's Tokyo sale listing, Jul 2026. Jewel: TTG Asia, "Jewel Changi Airport turns into a Lego floral wonderland," 19 Jun 2026.

SCREEN & SOUND · MUSIC

Steve Lacy breaks a three-year silence tomorrow, in the most crowded release week of the summer

Oh Yeah? is his first album since *Gemini Rights* turned him into a genre unto himself — and it lands the same day as Nolan's *The Odyssey* and a five-deep album slate.

Steve Lacy releases *Oh Yeah?* tomorrow, 17 July — his first full album since 2022's *Gemini Rights*, written and produced entirely by Lacy himself and centred on emotional isolation following a 2025 breakup. *Gemini Rights*' genre-blending falsetto funk made Lacy one of the most distinctive songwriters of his generation without a single major radio hit driving it; three years of near-total silence since has only sharpened anticipation for whatever direction the follow-up takes.¹

Lacy's album shares its release date with Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, which opens in Singapore today and in the US tomorrow — the film's critical reception is already established (near-unanimous raves through two rounds of embargo lifts, No. 43) and this desk holds its next genuine peg as the actual opening-weekend box office, not yet in. Worth flagging on its own terms: Nolan waded into the film's casting-and-fidelity backlash this week, calling the criticism "irrelevant" and drawing fresh pushback for the remark — a genuinely new development since No. 43's review-embargo coverage.²

Lacy's own trajectory is worth the brief detour: he first broke through as a teenage member of *The Internet* before *Gemini Rights*' 2022 solo run turned him into a genre unto himself, drawing comparisons that ranged from Prince to D'Angelo without ever quite settling into either lineage — a reminder that the most interesting pop records of the past five years have rarely arrived from where the algorithm expected them to.

Tyla's *A*POP* and Charli xcx's *Music, Fashion, Film* both land the same day, 24 July, setting up a genuine head-to-head between amapiano-inflected pop and Charli's Paris-recorded art-pop turn with A. G. Cook and Finn Keane — two artists who spent the past two years defining opposite ends of what "pop" means in 2026, releasing on the identical Friday. Neither camp is likely to concede much ground to the other in the inevitable comparison pieces that follow.

THE CHATTER — WHAT GEMINI RIGHTS LOYALISTS ARE ASKING

Fan forums and music-press previews are split on whether *Oh Yeah?* will lean back into *Gemini Rights*' genre-hopping intimacy or push toward something more expansive — early single teasers reportedly favour a rawer, more stripped-down production than the last record's lush multi-genre arrangements. This desk will treat the album on its own merits once it's actually out, not the pre-release teaser cycle.

IN BRIEF — A FIVE-DEEP RELEASE WEEK

Tyla, *A*POP* (24 Jul) and **Charli xcx, *Music, Fashion, Film*** (24 Jul) round out a stacked back half of the month; Ariana Grande's *Petal* closes it 31 July.

Bring Me The Horizon's *Count Your Blessings* | *Repented* (10 Jul) and the Rolling Stones' *Foreign Tongues* round out a busy month for legacy rock acts alongside the pop slate above.

3 yrs

SINCE STEVE LACY'S LAST FULL ALBUM — ONE OF THE LONGER GAPS BETWEEN RELEASES THIS DESK HAS TRACKED FOR AN ARTIST STILL THIS ACTIVELY DISCUSSED

For a household weighing which release to book first this weekend: reviews consistently describe *The Odyssey* as intense, epic-scale war-and-myth filmmaking rather than family-friendly viewing, while the live-action *Moana* remains the safer pick to watch with an 11-year-old later this summer — two very different Friday-night calculations from the same release calendar.

The Rolling Stones' *Foreign Tongues*, meanwhile, arrives as the band's first album since 2023's *Hackney Diamonds* and the second without Charlie Watts — though sessions the late drummer recorded before his death reportedly make a final appearance on the record, a genuinely poignant footnote for a band now well into its seventh decade of still, somehow, releasing new music rather than just touring the catalogue.

SOURCES · 1 Ultimate Classic Rock, "A Look Ahead to July 2026's New Music Releases," Jul 2026. 2 Fox News, "Christopher Nolan sparks fresh backlash after calling 'The Odyssey' criticism 'irrelevant,'" 15 Jul 2026; Forbes, "Round 2 Of 'The Odyssey' Early Reviews Arrive," 14 Jul 2026 (background, see No. 43).

THE FAMILY DESK · AI AT HOME

The gap between what kids do with AI and what parents think they do

New survey data puts real numbers on a suspicion most parents of an 11-year-old already have — general guidance only, not a diagnosis of any one household.

Recent survey data puts firm numbers on a familiar suspicion: 86 percent of children aged 9-17 now use AI tools, with nearly a quarter using them daily, most commonly chatbots (68 percent), voice assistants (58 percent) and educational apps (32 percent). The more striking finding is the awareness gap — 38 percent of children aged 10-17 reported using generative AI in the past week, while only 27 percent of their parents believed they had, an 11-point blind spot that shows up consistently across multiple survey instruments this year.¹

Deloitte's 2026 back-to-school survey found 49 percent of parents worried their children lean on AI tools too much, with loss of critical thinking (70 percent) ranking well above job-loss fears as the top concern. School readiness lags behind adoption: 28 percent of students already use generative AI in schoolwork, but only 33 percent of schools have formal usage guidelines, and 78 percent of educators say AI-assisted cheating has increased noticeably since 2024.²

DON'T BE ALARMIST

Every one of these numbers describes typical, mainstream use — homework help, a voice assistant, a chatbot for a school project — not a crisis. The genuinely useful finding isn't "kids use AI," which was never in doubt; it's the specific, measurable gap between a child's actual usage and a parent's belief about it. That gap is closeable with a direct conversation, not a device ban, and framing it as anything scarier than a communication gap risks parents either overreacting or, worse, tuning the whole subject out.

THE NUMBER THAT MATTERS MOST

Roughly 1 in 10 children say no parent or guardian has ever discussed AI safety with them at all — a far more actionable gap than the usage-volume headline, and the easiest one for a household to close this week.

11pt

GAP BETWEEN KIDS WHO REPORT USING GENERATIVE AI WEEKLY AND PARENTS WHO BELIEVE THEY DO

For a household with an 11-year-old specifically, the survey data's most useful cut is by age band rather than the aggregate 9-17 figure: usage climbs steeply through the tween years as homework complexity increases and peer normalisation sets in, meaning a household that hasn't yet had an explicit AI conversation is statistically more likely than not to be behind where its child's actual usage already sits, even if current use looks light. The gap tends to widen, not narrow, heading into the young-teen years this desk's reader is now approaching.

Practical starting points several education-focused surveys converge on: treat AI tools the way most households already treat search engines — a resource to be taught how to use critically, with an explicit conversation about when double-checking an AI answer matters, rather than a tool to simply forbid or simply hand over unsupervised. Framing it as a skill to build together, rather than a threat to police, tracks with what child-development researchers say produces the most durable safety habits.

SOURCES · 1 Lurie Children's, "AI and Parenting: Statistics on Usage, Benefits & Concerns," 2026; Investing.com, "Kids use more AI than parents think, study shows," Jul 2026 (Common Sense Media, "Generation AI"). 2 BizPacReview, "Many parents now worried their kids rely on AI way too much," 10 Jul 2026 (Deloitte 2026 Back-to-School survey); Digital Trends, "Parents worry AI is becoming a crutch," Jul 2026. This item is general guidance, not medical, clinical or educational advice.

THE FAMILY DESK · AI COMPANIONS

What happens when a child asks a chatbot for health or emotional advice instead of a parent

More than half of kids who use AI turn to it for advice on their body or feelings — the specific sub-use paediatricians say deserves the closest attention.

Building on the general AI-usage gap this desk flagged on the facing page, the more specific concern researchers and paediatricians are converging on is what kids actually ask AI for: more than half of children who use AI tools turn to them for advice on their health or body, and a US survey of 13-to-17-year-olds found 72 percent have used an AI companion, with 52 percent qualifying as regular users and a third saying they've chosen an AI companion over a human for a serious conversation. A separate accuracy study of five popular chatbots found consumers received "problematic" medical advice roughly half the time — accuracy no better than a coin flip.¹

Common Sense Media's 2025 risk assessment concluded AI companions pose an "unacceptable risk" to under-18s, citing chatbots that repeatedly failed to respond appropriately to teens expressing thoughts of self-harm; Character.ai banned all under-18 users that same year after lawsuits alleged chatbot interactions contributed to teen psychological distress. University of Virginia researchers separately warn that AI's instant, always-available affirmation is a specific concern for the adolescent brain, which is unusually responsive to that kind of validation.²

The AAP's standing guidance on this is unambiguous and worth repeating exactly: AI chatbots can support patient engagement, but "the very best source of information about your child's health care is your pediatrician," particularly around anything touching diagnosis or treatment — a distinction worth making explicit to a child directly, not just holding as a parental rule enforced from behind.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

An 11-year-old asking a chatbot "does this rash look bad?" is a different, much lower-stakes event than a teenager substituting an AI companion for human friendship during a mental-health crisis — the research above spans that whole range, and treating every AI health question as equivalent to the Character.ai lawsuits would be its own kind of overreaction. The useful distinction is between AI as an occasional reference tool (fine, with adult follow-up) and AI as a replacement for a real relationship or a real doctor (the genuine risk).

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICAL TAKE

Treat an AI health answer as a starting question, not an ending one — "let's ask the doctor about that too" keeps the tool useful without letting it substitute for a real diagnosis.

Ask what she'd tell an AI that she wouldn't tell you. Paediatric guidance frames this less as a trick question and more as the actual opening move for the safety conversation roughly 1 in 10 households still hasn't had (facing page).

~50%

RATE AT WHICH STUDIED CHATBOTS GAVE "PROBLEMATIC" MEDICAL ADVICE — NO BETTER THAN A COIN FLIP

The Character.ai ban and Common Sense Media's risk rating both moved fast relative to how young this technology category is — a reminder that "wait and see" is not this desk's standing advice on AI-companion products specifically, even though it is the standing advice on most new consumer tech. The two categories genuinely aren't the same risk profile, and this desk will keep treating them differently.

This item is general guidance drawn from published research, not medical, clinical or psychological advice for any individual child; a paediatrician or school counsellor remains the right first call for a specific concern.

SOURCES · 1 Lurie Children's, "AI and Parenting: Statistics on Usage, Benefits & Concerns," 2026; Child Mind Institute, "AI Chatbots and Teens," 2026; Shaw Local, "Patients turning to AI chatbots for medical advice, risking dangerous missteps," 23 Jun 2026. 2 PIRG, "The risks of AI companion chatbots as mental health support," 2026 (Common Sense Media risk assessment); Social Media Victims Law Center, "AI Chatbot Companions: Impact on Children and Teens," 2026; 29News, "UVA experts warn of risks as children turn to AI for emotional support," 31 Mar 2026.

THE MACRO DESK · MARKET EXPLANATION, NOT ADVICE

Apple hits a record high the same session chipmakers fall as much as 8%

Wednesday's rally split cleanly down the middle — mega-cap AI winners versus the suppliers caught in Nvidia's new China-compliance squeeze.

S&P 500 7,572 ▲	NASDAQ 26,269 ▲	US 10Y ~4.56% ▼	DXY ~100.6 ▼	GOLD ~\$4,073 ▲	BTC ~\$64.6k ▲
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Wednesday's session extended the relief rally that followed Tuesday's cooler-than-expected June CPI print (No. 43) for a second day, but it split sharply by sector. The S&P 500 closed up 0.38 percent to 7,572.40 and the Nasdaq 0.62 percent to 26,269.23, with Apple hitting a fresh all-time high and Amazon, Alphabet and Microsoft all rising roughly 3 percent — mega-cap AI-adjacent names extending Tuesday's disinflation trade. Chipmakers moved the opposite direction: Micron fell 8 percent, Lam Research and AMD each dropped 3 percent, Intel more than 4 percent, a decline that lines up closely with Nvidia's new Asia-compliance whitelist tightening supply-chain certainty across the sector (see Technology, [p7](#)).¹

The US dollar index fell for a second straight session to roughly 100.6, its weakest run in weeks, as softer inflation data continued to erode near-term Fed-hike expectations; CME FedWatch has traders pricing an 84.5 percent probability the Fed holds rates unchanged at its July meeting, though a nearly 60 percent chance of a quarter- or half-point hike by October persists in the same dataset — a genuinely split market view on the medium-term path. The 10-year Treasury yield eased toward 4.56 percent on the same rate-relief mood.²

Oil moved the other way again: Brent-linked crude eased to roughly \$79 even as the Hormuz blockade entered its fourth wave of strikes (see The World, [p3](#)) — a reminder that the war-risk premium and the rate-cut trade are pulling on the same barrel from opposite directions, with rate relief currently the stronger force.³

Apple's record high and Micron's 8% drop happened in the same session — proof the "AI trade" and the "chip-supply trade" are no longer the same trade.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

The dominant force on a VWRA-plus-global-bonds portfolio remains the cooling rate-hike odds — easier yields help both anchors at once, which is why the sector split within equities matters less to a globally diversified holder than it does to a chip-sector stock-picker. A global-aggregate bond proxy (AGGU, last confirmed ~5.84) should be reading the same easier-yield tailwind as VWRA this week. Gold is essentially flat (~\$4,073, +0.16%) — torn between the real-yield tailwind from softer rates and a fading haven bid now that the Hormuz toll itself is resolved, even as the shooting war continues. Bitcoin's Tuesday CPI-driven surge (+4.4%) has partly faded by Wednesday, consistent with its usual behaviour as a high-beta liquidity proxy rather than a haven — neither move is a signal to act on.

RATE RELIEF

CHIP-SECTOR SELLOFF

DOLLAR WEAKER

SOURCES · 1 TheStreet, "Stock Market Today (July 15, 2026): SpaceX dips below IPO price for first time," 15 Jul 2026; Yahoo Finance, "Stock market today: Dow, S&P 500, Nasdaq slip as semiconductor stocks plummet," 15 Jul 2026. 2 Benzinga, "Will S&P 500 Open Up or Down Today?," 15 Jul 2026 (CME FedWatch); Vantage Markets, "US Dollar Index Today," 15 Jul 2026. 3 Trading Economics, crude oil and US dollar index series, 15 Jul 2026; Fortune, "Current price of gold," 15 Jul 2026; Yahoo Finance, "Bitcoin and ethereum prices today," 15 Jul 2026.

CURIOSITIES • SPACE

A four-test checklist narrows the hunt for an alien megastructure

A University of Arkansas study times its search criteria to 2026's rare convergence of three major space telescopes.

A University of Arkansas study published in the journal *Universe* this month lays out a four-test scientific checklist for spotting a Dyson sphere — the hypothetical alien megastructure built to capture a star's entire energy output — timed deliberately to 2026's convergence of the James Webb Space Telescope, the newly operational Vera C. Rubin Observatory and the Roman Space Telescope. The tests centre on temperature and dust signatures: a genuine Dyson swarm should glow almost entirely in infrared, run unusually cold (as low as 50 Kelvin around a host star that would otherwise read near 3,000K), and show a suspiciously "clean" spectrum — radiator panels, not the silicate dust disks that surround ordinary stars.¹

The study identifies red dwarfs and white dwarfs as the most promising targets, on the logic that an advanced civilisation could build an energy-harvesting swarm around a smaller, cooler star more easily than around one like the Sun. It follows a separate survey that has already flagged 60 Dyson sphere candidate stars out of the millions searched by infrared surveys to date — none confirmed, all still explainable by ordinary astrophysics, but the new checklist gives astronomers a sharper set of criteria to rule candidates in or out as the three telescopes' 2026 data starts arriving in volume.²

THE CHATTER — SETI'S OWN CAUTION

SETI Institute researchers have been consistently careful to note that every "coldest star" candidate found so far has a mundane astrophysical explanation available — a dust cloud, a background-source contamination, an unusual but natural cooling star. The new checklist's real value, in this framing, is less "how to find one" than "how to stop wasting telescope time on false positives" — a filter, not a discovery claim.

ALSO THIS WEEK

A predator caught mid-bite, fossilised. Palaeontologists described a fossilised *Edmontosaurus* skull with a *Tyrannosaurus* tooth still embedded in its face — rare direct physical evidence of a specific predator-prey encounter, rather than the usual inference from bite marks alone.

Turquoise water, seen from orbit. NASA's PACE satellite captured the Black Sea glowing turquoise during its annual phytoplankton bloom, the colour produced by billions of reflective coccolithophore shells bright enough to register from space.

60

DYSON SPHERE CANDIDATE STARS FLAGGED SO FAR
AMONG THE MILLIONS SEARCHED — NONE CONFIRMED, ALL
STILL EXPLAINABLE NATURALLY

A DNA PRINTER ON A CHIP

Researchers have built a silicon chip that writes dozens of DNA sequences simultaneously using electricity and water-based enzymes rather than the toxic reagents conventional DNA synthesis requires — early-stage, but a cleaner path toward cheaper, faster genetic manufacturing for research and medicine alike.

A joint Aalto University and University of Jyväskylä team reported the first direct experimental confirmation of a topological crystalline insulator, a two-dimensional quantum material theoretically predicted more than a decade ago. It is genuinely early-stage physics — but the kind of confirmed result that eventually feeds into next-generation, lower-power computing hardware.

SOURCES • 1 TechTimes, "Dyson Sphere Hunt Gains Four-Test Checklist as Webb, Rubin, Roman Converge," 11 Jul 2026; ScienceDaily, "The galaxy's coldest 'stars' may actually be alien megastructures," 10 Jul 2026 (University of Arkansas, journal *Universe*). 2 EarthSky, "Astronomers find 60 Dyson sphere candidates," Jul 2026; SETI Institute, "Have We Really Detected Dyson Spheres?," 2026. *Edmontosaurus*: ScienceDaily paleontology desk, Jul 2026. PACE/Black Sea: NASA Science, Jul 2026. DNA chip and topological insulator: ScienceDaily, Jul 2026.

LOVE & LIFE · RELATIONSHIPS

A Zurich study puts a number on the real cost of staying single into your late twenties

The decline is real and measurable — but the same data complicates the idea that marriage itself is the fix.

A University of Zurich study tracking young adults over time finds that people who remain single for an extended period show a sharper decline in life satisfaction and rising loneliness than their partnered peers, with the gap widening most sharply in the late twenties — the same window depression symptoms tend to rise. The researchers link the pattern partly to a stronger educational focus that pushes committed relationships later, rather than treating singlehood itself as the sole cause; the effect holds similarly for men and women.¹

The nuance worth holding alongside that finding: Gallup polling separately shows singles are more than twice as likely to report loneliness as married people, yet up to 30 percent of married people also report feeling lonely while living under the same roof as a partner — meaning a wedding ring is correlated with, but doesn't guarantee, the outcome the headline number implies. The honest read is that sustained social connection, not marital status specifically, is the variable doing the real work.²

The Zurich researchers are careful to separate two claims that popular coverage of the study often collapses into one: that staying single longer correlates with a well-being decline (well-supported in this data) and that marriage itself is the fix (much weaker support, once the loneliness-among-married figures are factored in). The more defensible reading is that sustained, high-quality social connection — which marriage often but not always provides — is the actual mechanism, and that singlehood becomes costly specifically when it also

THE CHATTER — 2026'S DATING TRENDS

Dating-trend coverage this year converges on "clear-coding" — being upfront early about whether you want marriage, a serious relationship, or something casual — alongside a broader "slow dating" shift toward fewer, more deliberate connections over app-fatigue swiping. Roughly half of surveyed singles say they prefer partners actively in therapy, and 12 percent actively filter for it; micro-dating (short, low-stakes first meetups) is gaining traction as a lower-pressure alternative to a full first date.

WORTH HOLDING ONTO

42 percent of singles report dating outside their usual "type" this year — the study's authors read this as evidence that values-based compatibility is displacing surface-level attraction as singles' primary filter, a genuinely more durable basis for the relationships that do form.

Micro-dating — short, low-stakes first meetups over app-mediated small talk — is gaining traction specifically as a lower-pressure way to test the values-fit these studies say actually predicts durable connection.

AI companionship is expected to rise among burnt-out daters seeking connection on their own terms — a trend this desk will revisit once independent research on its actual well-being effects exists, rather than take the marketing at face value.

2×

HOW MUCH MORE LIKELY SINGLES ARE TO REPORT LONELINESS THAN MARRIED PEOPLE — THOUGH UP TO 30% OF MARRIED PEOPLE REPORT IT TOO

means social isolation rather than simply the absence of a legal or romantic partnership.

The "slow dating" and "clear-coding" trends this desk has tracked all year read, in that light, less as a retreat from commitment and more as an attempt to filter for exactly the kind of durable connection the Zurich data says actually matters — a generation that came of age on high-volume swiping apps recalibrating toward fewer, deeper prospects rather than abandoning the search for partnership altogether.

SOURCES · 1 Futurity, "Staying single long-term may be bad for your well-being," Jan 2026 (University of Zurich); phys.org, "Staying single for longer affects young people's well-being, study finds," Jan 2026. 2 Newsweek, "Can Marriage Save America From Loneliness Epidemic? Study Suggests It Can," 2026. Dating trends: Vice, "5 Rising Dating Trends to Look Out for in 2026"; It's Just Lunch, "Dating Trends for 2026," Jul 2026.

FITNESS · LONGEVITY

The exact weekly dose of strength training that buys the most years

A 30-year, 147,000-person dataset finally puts a number on the "how much is enough" question this desk gets asked most.

A study published in the British Journal of Sports Medicine, drawing on 147,374 people tracked over 30 years, finds that 90 to 120 minutes of resistance training a week is the longevity sweet spot — associated with a 13 percent lower risk of death from any cause and a 19 percent lower risk of cardiovascular death, with benefits plateauing beyond that range rather than continuing to climb. Adding aerobic exercise to the same weekly mix increased the benefit further, but the resistance-training dose itself is the headline: roughly 15-20 minutes, four to six days a week, not an hour-long daily session.¹

A separate Harvard T.H. Chan analysis of more than 111,000 adults over three decades found that exercise variety, not just volume, independently predicts longevity: the highest-variety group had a 19 percent lower risk of premature death than the lowest-variety group, holding total exercise time roughly constant — mixing modalities appears to matter on its own, not merely as a proxy for doing more overall.²

THE CHATTER — THE "YOU DON'T NEED TO SUFFER" THREAD

A wave of 2026 strength-training research is converging on a simpler message than the fitness-influencer default: slow, controlled lowering movements build strength efficiently with less total effort, and even five minutes a day of basic moves — chair squats, wall push-ups — produces measurable gains for previously sedentary adults. Strength training has overtaken weight loss as America's top stated fitness goal for 2026, a genuine shift toward the longevity framing this desk has been tracking all year.

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

These are population-level associations, not a prescription for any individual's training plan, especially alongside existing joint, cardiac or other conditions — a physiotherapist or physician remains the right first call before starting a new resistance programme.

90–120

MINUTES OF WEEKLY STRENGTH TRAINING LINKED TO THE LOWEST ALL-CAUSE MORTALITY RISK — MORE ISN'T SHOWN TO HELP FURTHER

Reading the two studies together produces a more concrete weekly template than either offers alone: roughly four sessions of 20-30 minutes of resistance work, spread across the week rather than compressed into one or two long sessions, with genuine variety in movement pattern — a squat, a hinge, a push, a pull, rotated rather than repeated identically — appears to capture both the dose-response sweet spot and the variety benefit simultaneously. Neither study tested that

exact combined protocol directly, but it's the most defensible synthesis of what both independently found.

The "you don't need intense workouts" research strand matters most for anyone who has previously written off strength training as too time-consuming or too demanding to start: five minutes of chair squats or wall push-ups a day is a genuinely low enough bar that the usual excuse mostly stops applying.

SOURCES · 1 Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, "Moderate amount of strength training each week could boost longevity," Jun 2026 (British Journal of Sports Medicine, 2 Jun 2026). 2 Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, "Exercise variety — not just amount — linked to lower risk of premature mortality," Jan 2026. ScienceDaily, "You don't need intense workouts to build muscle, new study reveals," 1 May 2026; ScienceDaily, "The best strength training plan might be simpler than you think," 19 Mar 2026. This item is general guidance, not medical advice.

THE DIARY · THE AGENDA

ENHYPEN's general sale lands tomorrow; BIGBANG's Singapore silence stretches into a ninth straight issue

National Day tickets aside, this fortnight's calendar is dominated by presales, not yet purchases — worth flagging early rather than late.

SINGAPORE

DATED & CONFIRMED

- 9
AUG

★ National Day Parade — The Padang/Marina Bay

SINGAPORE'S 61ST; THE ISLAND-WIDE "MAJULAH HUNT" DIGITAL TREASURE HUNT RUNS IN THE LEAD-UP
- 17
OCT

★ BIGBANG — National Stadium

20/26 WORLD TOUR · CONFIRMED SINCE NO. 27; SG ON-SALE/PRICING STILL UNANNOUNCED — 9TH STRAIGHT ISSUE
- 14
MAR
27

★ ENHYPEN — National Stadium

BLOOD SAGA WORLD TOUR · GENERAL SALE OPENS TOMORROW, 17 JUL, AFTER WEDNESDAY'S ENGINE PRESALE
- 26
JUL

EXO — Singapore Indoor Stadium

EXHORIZON WORLD TOUR, FIRST SG RETURN SINCE 2019
- 18
AUG

Simple Plan — Singapore Indoor Stadium

\$98–\$148, VIA SISTIC

JAPAN & REGION

WORTH THE TRIP

- 21–24
JUL

Sotheby's Watch Auction — Tokyo

WORTH WATCHING FOR WHETHER THE INDEPENDENT-WATCHMAKER PREMIUM (SEE THE GOOD LIFE, [p11](#)) TRAVELS EAST
- 24–26
JUL

Fuji Rock Festival — Naeba, Niigata

THE XX, TURNSTILE, MASSIVE ATTACK, FUJII KAZE
- 31
JUL–2
AUG

Muro Festival — Odaiba, Tokyo

CITY FESTIVAL, DIVERCITY TOKYO PLAZA

PLANNING NOTES

ENHYPEN's general sale opens 17 July via Ticketmaster SG after this week's ENGINE-membership presale; the tour's other legs have sold out within hours elsewhere, so treat tomorrow's opening bell as the real window. BIGBANG's silence has now run nine straight issues against a locked venue and date — genuinely anomalous rather than routine at this point, with no explanation offered by promoter AEG Presents or the group's own channels. Family-friendliness: National Day and EXO both draw a broad family crowd; BIGBANG and Simple Plan skew older/teen.

National Day's Majulah Hunt digital treasure hunt is worth booking into the calendar now rather than closer to 9 August: the island-wide format rewards spreading stops across several weekends rather than a single rushed day, and it pairs naturally with the NDP's own build-up programming for a household with a school-age child keen to feel part of the lead-up rather than just the fireworks.

For a household weighing a Tokyo trip around Fuji Rock's remote Naeba setting, Sotheby's Tokyo watch sale (21–24 July, see [The Good Life](#), [p11](#)) sits inside the same travel window — worth checking viewing-day access even for a non-bidder, since major-house preview exhibitions are typically open to the public and make for a genuinely interesting half-day stop between festival dates.

SOURCES · Ticketmaster SG event listings; ygfamily.com concert page, Jul 2026 (BIGBANG). Sotheby's watches department calendar, Jul 2026. Fuji Rock/Muro: arigatotravel.com, Tokyo Dome schedule, Jul 2026. National Day: NDP 2026 EXCO, Majulah Hunt launch materials, Jul 2026. Simple Plan: SISTIC listing, Jul 2026.

THE TABLE · NEWEST OPENINGS

A CBD ramen counter finally gets its verdict, and a 1980s Korean herbal shop opens as a restaurant

MENSHO X's first independent reviews close a two-issue "too new to call" thread; a Blue Box Café opens too fresh to judge; and Novena gets something genuinely unusual.

MENSHO X — VERDICT IN

Flagged "opened 14 July, too new for review" in No. 43, the Raffles Place fast-casual outpost of Tokyo's Michelin-recognised Mensho ramen house has now drawn its first independent write-ups.

BUZZ

Consensus is positive: reviewers single out the creamy Toripaitan broth and a spicy "Firebird" upgrade, with the sake-kasu-marinated kurobuta pork chashu called "fantastic" — juicy, umami-deep, subtly fruity. The lean, CBD-friendly menu (mostly under S\$22) delivers real value for money; the one consistent knock is presentation polish rather than flavour. A solid, genuinely recommended addition — not a must-queue destination, but a real one.

VERDICT: RECOMMENDED

CLOSED THREAD

BLUE BOX CAFÉ — ION ORCHARD

Tiffany & Co.'s first Southeast Asian café opened Wednesday on the newly renovated boutique's top floor, designed by Peter Marino, with a Julien Royer (three-Michelin-starred Odette)-built menu split into Breakfast, All Day Dining and Tea services. Just over 20 seats, dressed floor-to-ceiling in signature Tiffany Blue.

BUZZ

Too new for an independent critical verdict — opened the day before this issue closed. Early description: a Tiffany Burger (\$34++, thick wagyu patty) and a Confit Yellow Chicken (\$48++, tableside Albufera sauce) headline the menu; reservations were already filling fast pre-opening. Next peg: first paying-table reviews.

OPENED YESTERDAY

TOO NEW TO CALL

NEW THIS WEEK

A new samgyetang specialty restaurant has opened in Novena Square, styled after a 1980s Korean herbal-medicine shop — an unusually specific design concept for a ginseng-chicken-soup menu, and a genuine change of register from the sukiyaki-and-ramen wave this desk has tracked most of the year. No independent review yet; too new to call, but worth a look for the concept alone.¹

MENSHO X's closed thread is a useful data point on how long "too new to call" should actually last: two issues, in this case — roughly the gap between an opening and a genuine independent lunch-crowd verdict for a CBD fast-casual counter, versus the three issues Suki-yaki Jin needed as a full-service, higher-price venue (No. 43). The format and price point of a restaurant seem to predict its own review timeline about as reliably as anything else this desk tracks.

The Blue Box Café's opening-week trajectory is worth watching against Suki-yaki Jin's own arc: a heavily pre-hyped concept with a Michelin-chef collaboration and under two dozen seats is precisely the combination that tends to produce either a rapturous first wave of reviews or a sharp price-versus-value backlash, with comparatively little middle ground — this desk will report whichever way it actually breaks, not the one the pre-opening buzz predicts.

THE HONESTY LEDGER

VENUE	STATUS	NEXT PEG
MENSHO X (Raffles Pl)	Reviewed — recommended	Closed (No. 44)
Blue Box Café	Opened 15 Jul	First paying-table reviews
Novena samgyetang shop	Open, unreviewed	First independent verdict

Behind Clay and Yi Man Fen Dessert (both flagged "still on the shelf" in No. 43) remain open with no new independent review to report; per this desk's pruning rule, they roll off the active ledger here rather than repeat a third unchanged mention.

SOURCES · Eatbook, "Mensho X Review: \$17++ By Michelin-Approved Brand," Jul 2026; HungryGoWhere, "Mensho X at Raffles Place," Jul 2026. Blue Box Café: TheSmartLocal, Eatbook, MustVisit.sg, Grazia Singapore, Jul 2026. 1 EatBook/TimeOut new-openings roundups, Jul 2026 (Novena samgyetang).

THE LONG READ

An Election, Not Postponed

Kyiv holds a parliamentary vote for a new prime minister today, in the middle of an active war. This issue's real theme is everything else that also refused to wait for calmer weather.

Sometime this afternoon, Kyiv time, Ukraine's parliament will vote on whether to confirm Serhii Koretskyi as prime minister — a scheduled, procedural event, held on schedule, in a country under sustained missile and drone attack on its energy grid, mid-resuffle, with winter already the stated priority of the man being confirmed to help survive it. Nothing about the moment demanded the vote happen today rather than next month. It is happening today because that is what the calendar said, and because a government that keeps its own procedural clock running, even under fire, is making a specific and legible claim about itself.¹

There is a precedent for this that is almost uncomfortably exact, and it belongs to Abraham Lincoln. In the autumn of 1864, with the Civil War in its fourth year and no guaranteed end in sight, the United States held a presidential election on schedule — not a ceremonial vote in a safe rear area, but a genuine, contested national election, conducted while the Union's own survival was still an open question. Lincoln himself believed for much of that year that he would lose it; his cabinet drafted contingency plans on the assumption of defeat. He let the vote happen anyway.²

He also said, afterward, precisely why. Serenaded on the White House lawn two days after the result was known, Lincoln told the crowd: "We can not have free government without elections; and if the rebellion could force us to forego, or postpone a national election, it might fairly claim to have already conquered and ruined us." The line is worth sitting with in full, because it names the actual mechanism at stake — not that the election was a nice democratic gesture to make time for if the war allowed it, but that skipping it would have been a

second, quieter defeat layered underneath whatever happened on the battlefield. A government that lets a crisis cancel its own procedures has already conceded something no army can take by force.³

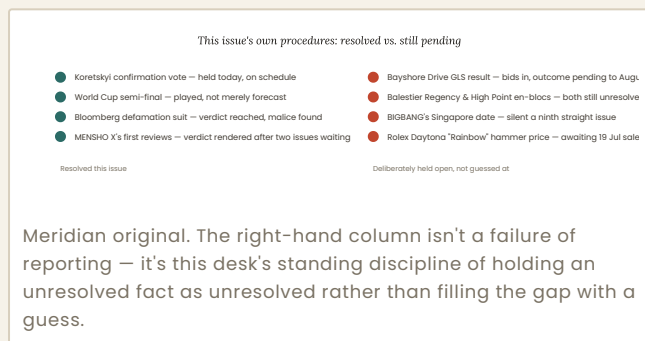
A government that lets a crisis cancel its own procedures has already conceded something no army could take from it by force.

Koretskyi's confirmation vote today is smaller in every sense — a cabinet appointment, not a national referendum on the war itself — but it shares Lincoln's exact logic in miniature. Ukraine's institutions could have let the reshuffle drift, citing the obvious excuse of an active war on two fronts (the shooting one, and the parallel effort to keep the lights on this winter). Instead the dismissal vote happened 258-1 on Tuesday, the nomination was announced Wednesday, and the confirmation vote lands today, exactly as scheduled. The war has not been paused for any of it. That is rather the point.

It is worth being precise about what this argument is not claiming. It is not a claim that procedure is more important than outcome, or that a vote held on schedule is automatically a vote held well — Lincoln's own 1864 election was fought on real, substantive terms, not treated as a formality to be rubber-stamped for appearance's sake. The claim is narrower and, this issue keeps arguing, more useful: that the decision to let a scheduled process run its course, rather than defer it until conditions feel calmer, is itself a legible signal about an institution's actual state — separate from, and prior to, whatever that process eventually produces.

SOURCES · 1 See The World, [p4](#); Al Jazeera, Kyiv Independent, 14–15 Jul 2026. 2 History.com, "How Abraham Lincoln Won Re-Election During the Civil War," 2026; The Conversation, "1864 elections went on during the Civil War," 2026. 3 Lincoln, response to a White House serenade, 10 Nov 1864 — standard text, widely reproduced (Libquotes, Quotefancy, and primary Lincoln collections).

Widen the lens past Kyiv and this issue is unusually full of the same small logic playing out in domains that carry nothing like a war's stakes. Singapore's Q2 GDP print landed on schedule Tuesday, beating forecast, without anyone needing to argue the statistics office into publishing it on time (No. 43). A World Cup semi-final that plenty of neutral commentary expected England to win instead had to actually be played, on a real pitch, in real time, before Argentina's result existed as a fact rather than a prediction (see The World, [p4](#)). A defamation suit that had run since a December 2024 article reached its scheduled verdict this week, with a judge's finding standing in for what had previously been two competing claims (see Singapore, [p5](#)). None of these needed a war to test them. They needed only their own procedure to run to completion instead of being deferred.



The contrast on the right-hand side of that ledger is deliberate, and it is the essay's actual hinge. This issue is just as full of things that did not resolve on schedule — a GLS tender whose result URA will take weeks to announce, two en-bloc sales stuck past their own tender deadlines, a concert date that has now gone unexplained for nine consecutive issues. None of those are failures on Meridian's part to find out the answer; they are the honest, harder discipline this desk tries to model every week, of refusing to convert "not yet known" into "probably this," just because a guess would read more satisfyingly than an open question.¹

Put the two columns side by side and a distinction comes into focus that Lincoln's line also implies without spelling out: a procedure that runs to completion on schedule is not automatically producing a good outcome — Argentina's win doesn't

validate the fixture any more than England's loss discredits it — but a procedure that quietly gets postponed, deferred, or replaced with a guess has already failed in a way no eventual outcome can repair. The Rada's vote today might yet produce a prime minister who struggles through winter. That would still be a wholly different kind of event than a Rada that simply stopped voting because the war made voting inconvenient.

The Macro Desk's own market strip this issue ([p15](#)) is a smaller, faster-moving version of the same left-right split. Wednesday's session let Apple close at a record high and Micron fall eight percent inside the same four hours — two genuinely contradictory verdicts about the same broad AI-compute trade, reached by the same market, on the same day, because two separate processes (a disinflation trade and a compliance-driven supply shock) both ran to completion simultaneously rather than waiting for each other to resolve first. Markets, like parliaments, don't pause one open question to let another one finish.

There is also an honest limit to how far this logic travels, and the essay owes the reader that limit rather than smoothing past it. Plenty of processes get deferred for entirely defensible reasons — URA's multi-week evaluation window for the Bayshore Drive tender ([p6](#)) exists because a rushed land-sale verdict would be a worse outcome than a careful one, not because anyone lost their nerve. The distinction this essay is actually drawing is between a deliberate, disclosed evaluation period and a process that simply goes quiet with no explanation offered — which is precisely what separates URA's Bayshore timeline from BIGBANG's nine-issue silence on the facing pages.

A disclosed timeline and a genuine silence look similar from the outside for exactly as long as both remain unresolved — which is why the discipline has to be procedural, not just a gut read. Ask whether anyone has said when or how the answer arrives, not whether the answer has arrived yet. URA says weeks. AEG Presents, on BIGBANG, has said nothing at all in either direction, across nine consecutive issues.

There's a reason this distinction matters more to this particular reader than it might first appear. A portfolio built on VWRA and global bonds, an ageing parent's medical screening calendar, a child's school timeline, a retirement date picked years in advance — all of these are, at bottom, bets that certain procedures will keep running on schedule regardless of the news cycle layered on top of them: that a central bank will keep publishing its data, that a court will keep reaching verdicts, that a market will keep opening. The discipline this issue keeps modelling, desk after desk, is to watch specifically for whether the procedure ran, not just for whether the outcome was the one you wanted.

That is also, not coincidentally, the standard this desk tries to hold itself to. A CPI print, a GDP estimate, a market close, a hammer price — every one of them is a scheduled event with its own procedural integrity, separate from whether the resulting number is good or bad news for any given reader. The Macro Desk's whole method ([p15](#)) is built on the same distinction: report the print that actually landed, on the day it actually landed, and resist the temptation to smooth over the sessions where the story doesn't resolve as cleanly as a headline would like.

Lincoln's line was written about the single highest-stakes version of this problem democracy has ever produced — an election inside a war whose outcome was

genuinely uncertain, held by a president who expected to lose it. Koretskyi's confirmation vote today is a far smaller echo of the same choice, made by a country under fire that could plausibly have deferred it and been forgiven for doing so. It didn't. Neither, this week, did a statistics office, a football federation, a court, or — in its own much smaller register — a ramen counter that finally got the review it had been waiting two issues for. None of that guarantees any of this week's outcomes were good ones. It only guarantees they were real.

By the time this issue reaches its reader, Kyiv's parliament will very likely have voted. Meridian will not know the result before press time, and says so plainly rather than guessing at a number to make the sentence read more cleanly — the same discipline this desk applies to a GLS tender outcome, a hammer price, or a box-office weekend that hasn't happened yet. That gap between "the process ran" and "the result is known" is not a reporting failure. It's the entire distinction this essay has spent three pages trying to earn.

Consider it, if nothing else, a standing instruction for how to read next issue: watch for whether Koretskyi's government reaches its own next scheduled milestone — a first budget, a first winter-readiness report — on time. That will tell the reader more about Ukraine's institutional health than today's vote count ever could on its own.

THE THREADS — ELSEWHERE IN THIS ISSUE

A vote, not deferred. Ukraine's PM confirmation ([p4](#)) lands today, on schedule, mid-war — this essay's central case.

A verdict, finally rendered.

MENSHO X's first independent reviews ([p20](#)) closed a thread this desk had held open since No. 43.

Still honestly unresolved. The Bayshore Drive GLS result ([p6](#)) and BIGBANG's Singapore silence ([p19](#)) both remain open questions this issue declines to guess at.

Two processes, one market.

Apple's record close and Micron's 8% fall ([p15](#)) resolved in the same session, proof that a market can settle two contradictory questions at once.

A parliament voted today because the calendar said to, not because the war allowed it. A statistics office, a football federation and a ramen counter all kept their own separate clocks running this week too. None of it guarantees the outcomes were good ones — only that they were real, which this issue keeps arguing is the harder and more useful thing to check for.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 44

The World: CBS News, CNN, NPR, Yahoo News, Bloomberg, Al Jazeera, Kyiv Independent, ESPN/FIFA (14–15 Jul).

Singapore: Law.com International, Bloomberg, Mothership.SG, CPJ, SCMP, Bernama.

Property: 99.co, Bloomberg, URA media releases, PropertyNet.SG, Stacked Homes, EdgeProp, TracyGoh.sg.

Technology: Gurufocus, CNBC, Bloomberg, TechNode, DeepSeek API docs.

Kit / Connected Home: AndroidHeadlines, Gadget Hacks, The Ghost Howls, The Gadgeteer, Matter Alpha, home-assistant.io, TechTimes.

Good Life / Screen & Sound: Robb Report, The Art Newspaper, SimpleFlying, AviationA2Z, Forbes, Hollywood Reporter, Fox News, Ultimate Classic Rock.

Family: Lurie Children's, Investing.com/Common Sense Media, BizPacReview, Digital Trends, Favor Mental Health Services, Medical Daily,

Timily.

Macro: TheStreet, Yahoo Finance, Benzinga, Vantage Markets, Trading Economics, Fortune.

Curiosities: TechTimes, ScienceDaily, EarthSky, SETI Institute, NASA Science.

Love & Life: Futurity, phys.org (University of Zurich), Newsweek, Vice, It's Just Lunch.

Fitness: Harvard T.H. Chan School of Public Health, British Journal of Sports Medicine, ScienceDaily.

Diary / Table: Ticketmaster SG, ygfamily.com, Sotheby's, arigatotravel.com (Diary); Eatbook, HungryGoWhere, TheSmartLocal, MustVisit.sg, Grazia Singapore (The Table).

Long Read: History.com and The Conversation on the 1864 US election; Lincoln's 10 Nov 1864 White House serenade remarks, standard text.